EMERGING SCHOLARS COUNCIL

AMBITION TO ADMISSION



FREE HANDBOOK

Master's Admission in Europe 101

A practical handbook for Indian STEM students planning a Master's in Germany and across Europe

Dr. Deepak Kumar Malik · Founder, Emerging Scholars Council

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CONTENTS

What's inside

01	Welcome	4
02	Is a Master's abroad right for you?	5
03	How European Master's admissions work	7
04	Choosing programmes	9
05	Germany in depth	11
06	Other countries, briefly	14
07	Money	16
08	Your documents	18
09	Your 12-month plan	20
10	Visa and your first months	22
◆	What ESC offers for free	24

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Dr. Deepak Kumar Malik

Founder, Emerging Scholars Council · President, DAAD IndiAlumni

linkedin.com/in/deepmalik8281

I grew up in a village in Haryana, studied life sciences at Delhi University, and did my MSc at IIT Bombay in the Department of Biosciences and Bioengineering. I found my PhD at LMU Munich through a fully funded job advert, and finished it as a DAAD scholar. Today I work as a research scientist in Munich and serve as President of DAAD IndiAlumni, a registered non-profit association of Indian and German DAAD alumni. I started Emerging Scholars Council because I kept answering the same questions from students who were just as capable as anyone abroad, but had nobody to show them how the system works. This handbook is the honest version of those answers.

Want someone in your corner?

At Emerging Scholars Council, our mentors have been through these applications themselves. We work with you one-to-one: where to apply, how to present your research, your CV and letters, and your interviews. If you'd like to talk it through, book a free 15-minute call. Tell us where you are, and we'll tell you honestly what we'd do next.

Book a free call
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01

LMU Munich, Germany

CHAPTER 01 — START HERE

Welcome

Let me start with the honest part. Many Master's guides online are written by people selling something: a consultancy package, a loan, a private college seat. They make Europe sound easy and cheap. Some of it is cheap. None of it is easy.

I'm Dr. Deepak Kumar Malik. I did my MSc at IIT Bombay and my PhD at LMU Munich, so I didn't do a Master's abroad myself. But I've lived through German paperwork as an Indian student, and today I help students through this exact process at Emerging Scholars Council (ESC).

This handbook is for Indian students in or after a BSc, BS, BS-MS, BTech or BPharm. Many examples come from biology, but the logic works for every STEM field. You'll get the system in plain words, Germany in depth, a fair look at other countries, money, documents, the visa and your first months, and a 12-month plan you can print.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Rules, fees and deadlines change every year. The method doesn't. Learn how the system works and where to check the current rule, and this handbook stays useful long after 2026.

How to keep this handbook current

I've avoided freezing numbers that change often. Where a number really helps, I mark it "(approx., 2026)". Before you act on anything, check the official source:

1. **Your target programme's own web page.** It beats everything else, including this handbook.
2. **APS India** — aps-india.de — the APS certificate and the dMAT test, for Germany.
3. **German Missions in India** — india.diplo.de — the German student visa and the blocked account amount.

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4. **DAAD** — daad.de — German programmes and scholarships.
5. **uni-assist** — uni-assist.de — if your German university uses it.
6. **Make it in Germany** — make-it-in-germany.com — work rules and staying after graduation.
7. **Erasmus Mundus catalogue** — eacea.ec.europa.eu — fully funded joint Master's programmes.
8. **Each country's official study portal**, linked in the country chapter.

> **CHECK THE CURRENT RULE**
>
> If this handbook and an official page disagree, the official page wins. Always. Then please tell us, so we can fix the next edition.



02

Durham University, UK

CHAPTER 02 — THE BIG DECISION

Is a Master's abroad right for you?

A Master's abroad costs real money, even in "free" countries. It takes one to two years and moves you far from family. So be clear about why you're going before you choose a country.

Good reasons: you want a research career (in most of Europe, a PhD expects a Master's first); you want to switch or sharpen your field; you want to work in Europe after graduating; or Europe has far more programmes and labs in your exact area.

Weak reasons: "Everyone in my batch is going." "An agent told me Germany is free and easy." "I'll figure out the career part later." None of these will carry you through two hard years. Sharpen your reason first. Your motivation letter will thank you.

Your degree decides your options

BS-MS (5-year integrated, as at the IISERs). This is usually counted as a Master's-level degree. So you may be able to go straight to a PhD in Europe, which is almost always paid (never accept an unfunded one). Ask

the PhD programme whether they accept your degree, and for Germany look it up in anabin(anabin.kmk.org), the German database for foreign qualifications. A second Master's still makes sense mainly if you want to change field, your thesis was weak or unrelated, or you win a fully funded Master's such as Erasmus Mundus. Otherwise, put your energy into PhD applications. Our free PhD handbook covers that route.

3-year BSc. A full bachelor's degree, but some programmes expect a longer one. The next chapter explains credits.

BTech or BPharm. Usually enough credits. Your challenge is showing that your courses match the programme. BTech applicants going to Germany must also read about the new **dMAT** test.

FROM MY OWN EXPERIENCE

I did my MSc in India and got my PhD at LMU Munich by answering a fully funded job advert. A Master's in Europe is a good route, not the only one. Choose it because it fits your goal.

If a PhD is your long-term goal

Pick a research-heavy programme with lab rotations and a long thesis. Choose your thesis lab carefully, because labs often offer PhD positions to their strongest Master's students. Keep your grades strong. Build real working relationships with two or three professors who can write letters for you later.

What nobody tells you

"Free" isn't free. Even with no tuition, you pay living costs, deposits, insurance and flights for months before any salary. And some German universities now charge non-EU students.

The first months can be lonely. New language, short winter days, exams in a system you don't know. Feeling low at first is common. It isn't a sign you made a mistake. Talk to people, and use your university's counselling service if you need it.

The system is slow. APS, uni-assist, visa offices and landlords all work at their own speed. Build in extra time, keep copies, stay polite and follow up.

The study style is different. You're expected to work independently, exams can be oral, and grading is often stricter than at home. Ask questions early and form study groups.

Is it worth it? For a STEM student with a clear goal and a realistic budget, often yes. But it's not a shortcut. The students who do best planned for the hard parts.

> *"The students who do best planned for the hard parts."*

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03

University of Edinburgh, UK

CHAPTER 03 — THE SYSTEM

How European Master's admissions work

Each university runs its own admissions. But most of Europe shares one framework. Understand it, and everything else gets easier.

Credits: the Bologna system and ECTS

Most European countries follow the **Bologna system**: bachelor's, Master's, doctorate, with study measured in **ECTS credits** (European Credit Transfer and Accumulation System).

- One ECTS credit is roughly 25 to 30 hours of total work: lectures, labs, self-study and exams.
- One full year of study is about **60 ECTS**.
- A European Master's is usually **60 to 120 ECTS** (one to two years).

Your Indian degree has no ECTS, so the university (or uni-assist, for Germany) estimates them from your degree length and transcripts: often about 180 for a 3-year degree and 240 for a 4-year one.

This matters because some programmes require 210 or 240 ECTS from your bachelor's. If a programme asks for 240 and you have a 3-year BSc, you may not be eligible, however good your grades are.

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> Find the minimum credit requirement before you fall in love with a programme. It's usually under "admission requirements". If it's unclear, ask the programme coordinator. There's a template for that in the next chapter.

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Subject match

Most European Master's programmes are **consecutive**: they expect a bachelor's in the same or a closely related field, often with minimum credits per subject. Hold your transcript next to the requirements, line by line. If you're close but not exact, name the overlapping courses in your motivation letter.

Grade conversion

Universities convert your marks into their own scale. German grades run from 1.0 (best) to 4.0 (lowest pass). Many German universities use the **modified Bavarian formula**, but they apply it differently, so the same Indian percentage can give different German grades at different places.

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> Never trust a "percentage to German grade" chart from a blog. Use each university's own rules or calculator. uni-assist also states your converted grade in its evaluation.

Intakes and deadlines

Autumn (the winter semester, starting September or October) is the main intake almost everywhere. A **spring** intake (around March or April) exists for fewer programmes. Deadlines differ hugely, and non-EU applicants often face earlier ones because the visa takes time.

> **TIP**
>
> Make a spreadsheet with one row per programme: deadline, application route, credit rule, English requirement, fee, documents. It's the simplest protection against a missed deadline.

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04

Imperial College London, UK

CHAPTER 04 — SHORTLISTING

Choosing programmes

Your job isn't to apply everywhere. It's to find a small set where your background, your budget and your goal all fit.

Where to search

- The **DAAD International Programmes database** for Germany, through daad.de.
- The **Erasmus Mundus catalogue** for joint Master's across countries.
- **Country portals**: studyinnl.org, universityadmissions.se, campusfrance.org, studyinitaly.esteri.it.
- Search sites are fine for browsing, but the university's own page is the only source that counts.

Five checks before a programme makes your list

1. **Content.** Open the module handbook. Does it teach the methods you need, or just have a nice title?
2. **Entry fit.** Do you meet the credit, subject and grade rules on paper?
3. **Where it leads.** Are there labs, thesis projects or industry partners linked to your next step?
4. **Total cost.** A free programme in an expensive city can cost more than a fee-paying one in a small town.
5. **Your case.** Can you argue honestly and clearly that you belong there?

Most students do well with a focused list of roughly eight to twelve: a few ambitious, most realistic, one or two safe.

Red flags

Private colleges with weak recognition. Some are excellent. Others sell expensive degrees that don't lead where students expect. Check that the degree is state-accredited, that a public university there would

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accept it for a PhD, and what recent graduates actually do (look them up on LinkedIn).

Agents who promise too much. Be careful with anyone who promises "guaranteed admission" or charges large fees for applications you can do yourself. Many agents earn commission from the colleges they push. uni-assist itself says it doesn't work with commercial agencies.

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> Public universities don't need an agent to accept you. If someone charges you for access to a public university, ask exactly what you're paying for.

When the website doesn't answer your question

Read the programme's FAQ first. Then ask one clear question. One precise question gets a faster reply than five vague ones.

TEMPLATE Question to a Master's programme coordinator

```
Subject: Question on eligibility – [Programme name] – [Your name]

Dear [Name of coordinator, or "Programme Coordinator"],

I am planning to apply to the [programme name] for the [winter / summer] semester. I have read the admission requirements and the FAQ, but could not find an answer to one question.

I hold a [3-year / 4-year] [degree name] from [university, country]. My transcript includes [relevant courses, with credits or hours if known]. The programme asks for [quote the exact requirement].

Could you please tell me whether my degree would meet this requirement, or whether I should provide additional documents?

Thank you very much for your time.

Kind regards,
[Your full name]
[Email address]
```

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05

TU Munich, Germany

CHAPTER 05 — GERMANY

Germany in depth

Germany is still the most common choice for Indian STEM students: many English-taught Master's, strong research and a large Indian community. But the rules have changed a lot recently. Here they are, in order.

1. The APS certificate

APS (Akademische Prüfstelle, the Academic Evaluation Centre) is part of the German Embassy in New Delhi. It checks that your Indian documents are genuine and evaluates your qualifications. If you studied in India, you almost always need it for the student visa, and many universities ask for it too. It doesn't give you admission or a visa. It only confirms your documents. Apply at aps-india.de.

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> APS is the step students most often start too late. Processing takes weeks, longer in busy seasons. Start as soon as you're eligible.

2. The dMAT, for some subjects

In 2026 APS India added an aptitude test, the **dMAT** (Digital Master Test), for Master's applicants whose bachelor's is in **engineering**, **commerce, accounting, finance or economics**, or **business or management**. It applies from the summer semester 2027 intake onward.

- It's run at licensed test centres in India by an organisation called g.a.s.t.
- Your result appears on your APS certificate. APS India says it isn't a stand-alone pass or fail test, but universities see it, so prepare seriously.

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- You can submit APS documents before your dMAT result. The certificate is issued only after your dMAT result is checked.

A BSc in biology, chemistry, physics or maths isn't on the list as it stands. BTech students are affected. BPharm students should check the official list.

> **CHECK THE CURRENT RULE**
>
> The dMAT is new and may change. Affected fields, fees and test dates are on aps-india.de/dmat.

3. Recognition

Look up your university in **anabin**. Institutions marked **H+** are generally recognised. If yours has another status or isn't listed, ask the German university how they'll treat your degree before you spend money.

4. How you apply

Each programme tells you which of three routes it uses:

1. **uni-assist.** A service that checks international applications for more than 180 German universities. You pay a handling fee per application.
2. **VPD plus direct application.** A VPD is a uni-assist evaluation that confirms your eligibility and converts your grade. You get the VPD **and** apply through the university's own portal. A VPD alone is not an application.
3. **Direct.** The university handles everything itself.

> **TIP**
>
> uni-assist can take several weeks. Submit early, never in the final week.

5. Language

Many STEM Master's are taught fully in English and need an English test. German-taught ones need a high-level German certificate. Learn some German anyway: offices, landlords and most part-time jobs are much easier with it. The visa office has its own language rules, so read the German Missions' page before booking a test.

6. Tuition is no longer reliably free

As of October 2026:

- **Everyone** pays a **semester contribution** for student services, often including a transport ticket. DAAD gives roughly 100 to 350 euros per semester (approx., 2026).
- **Baden-Württemberg** (Heidelberg, Stuttgart, Freiburg, Tübingen, Karlsruhe and others) has charged non-EU students since 2017: 1,500 euros per semester (approx., 2026), with some exemptions.

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- In **Bavaria**, universities may now charge non-EU students. **TUM** has done so for new students since the winter semester 2024/25, with fees by programme plus waivers and scholarships. **FAU Erlangen-Nürnberg** follows from the summer semester 2027.
- Most other public universities still charge no non-EU tuition as of October 2026. But this is moving.

> **CHECK THE CURRENT RULE**
>
> Open the fee page of every German university on your list ("tuition fees for international students" or "Studiengebühren"). Check whether you pay, how much, and what waivers exist.

7. Deadlines and after graduation

There's no national deadline. For an October start, non-EU deadlines often fall between winter and late spring, and popular programmes can close much earlier. After graduating, non-EU students can get a permit of up to 18 months to look for a job matching their qualification, and may take any job meanwhile (approx., 2026). Details: make-it-in-germany.com.

STEP	WHAT IT IS	WHERE TO CHECK
APS	Document check	aps-india.de
dMAT	Test within APS, some fields	aps-india.de/dmat
Recognition	Is your university listed?	anabin.kmk.org
Application	uni-assist, VPD or direct	The programme page
Tuition	Free or fees for non-EU	Each fee page
Visa	National student visa	india.diplo.de

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06

Charles University, Prague, Czech Republic

CHAPTER 06 — BEYOND GERMANY

Other countries, briefly

I've left out fee amounts on purpose, because they change every year. The pattern is what matters.

COUNTRY	NON-EU TUITION	LIVING COSTS	CHECK
Netherlands	Set by each university; usually high	High; housing tight	studyinnl.org
Sweden	Tuition plus an application fee	Moderate to high	universityadmissions.se
France	Public: state-set fees, sometimes waived; grandes écoles higher	Paris high	campusfrance.org
Ireland	Set by each university; usually high	High; housing tight	University fee page
Switzerland	Low by world standards, but rising	Very high	University fee page
Italy	Public fees often linked to family income	Moderate	studyinitaly.esteri.it

Netherlands. Strong in life sciences, engineering and data science, almost all in English. Your university applies for your residence permit. The **NL Scholarship** gives a one-time amount in the first year, not full tuition. Graduates can apply for a one-year **orientation year** permit to look for work (approx., 2026; ind.nl). Housing is the biggest problem, so start looking the day you accept.

Sweden. Applications go through universityadmissions.se. The main round for international students usually opens in mid-October and closes in mid-January for an autumn start. **Swedish Institute** scholarships need work and leadership experience; check whether your country is on the current list at si.se. Graduates can get a permit of up to one year to look for work (approx., 2026; migrationsverket.se).

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France. Indian Master's applicants normally follow the **Études en France** procedure run by Campus France, which also feeds the visa (inde.campusfrance.org). For the **France Excellence Eiffel** scholarship, the French institution applies for you, so ask your programme early. Many programmes are in French, though English options are growing.

Ireland. English-speaking, with strong tech and pharma. Master's graduates can currently stay up to 24 months in total to look for work, in two 12-month steps (approx., 2026; irishimmigration.ie).

Switzerland. World-class research at ETH Zurich and EPFL, which raised fees sharply for foreign students from autumn 2025. Living costs are among Europe's highest and admission is very competitive. Look here if your profile is strong and your funding is clear.

Italy. Regional "right to study" (DSU) scholarships support students in financial need. Non-EU students first pre-enrol on the **Universitaly** portal, then apply for the visa. Your university may ask for a **Declaration of Value** or a **CIMEA** statement on your Indian degree.

Erasmus Mundus: fully funded, across countries

Erasmus Mundus Joint Master's programmes are run by groups of universities, and you usually study in at least two countries. The best applicants get a full scholarship covering participation costs plus a contribution to travel, visa and living costs. You apply to each programme directly. Most deadlines fall **between October and January** for the following autumn, earlier than almost everything else. They're very competitive, but the bar is merit and fit, not family money.

> **KEY TAKEAWAY**
>
> Compare countries by total cost, post-study options and how well the programmes fit your goal. Not by what your friends chose.

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07

University of Manchester, UK

CHAPTER 07 — FUNDING

Money

For many students, money causes more stress abroad than exams. Plan it properly.

Your four costs

1. **Tuition**, if your programme charges it.
2. **Semester or registration fees**, which almost everyone pays.
3. **Living costs**: rent, food, health insurance, transport, phone.
4. **One-time costs**: application fees, APS, tests, visa, flights, housing deposits, setting up.

People forget the fourth group. Add it all up before you commit. For living costs, start with the official estimate on the country portal, then check real room rents in your actual city, because rent is the biggest variable.

The German blocked account

For a German student visa you usually prove you can pay for your first year. The most common way is a **blocked account** (Sperrkonto): you deposit a year's money before the visa, then withdraw a fixed amount each month after you arrive.

- The amount follows the support rates for German students, so it changes, often yearly. For 2026, the German Missions in India give 11,904 euros for the first year, with up to 992 euros per month (approx., 2026).
- Several approved providers let you open one from India.
- A scholarship or a formal commitment from a sponsor in Germany can sometimes replace it.

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> **CHECK THE CURRENT RULE**
>
> Check the current amount at india.diplo.de before you transfer money. And treat it as the official minimum, not a comfortable budget. In Munich or Frankfurt, rent alone can eat much of it.

Part-time work

In Germany, non-EU students may work up to **140 full days or 280 half days a year**, or up to **20 hours a week during the semester** (approx., 2026). Student-assistant work at your university is treated more generously; self-employment needs separate permission. Check make-it-in-germany.com. Other countries set their own limits.

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> Breaking work rules can cost you your residence permit. And part-time work rarely covers everything, especially in your first months. Don't build a budget that only works if you find a job in week two.

Scholarships

The honest picture: fully funded Master's scholarships exist, but they're far rarer than funded PhD positions. Most students combine savings, family support, loans, part-time work and small scholarships. Fight hard for a scholarship, but plan without one.

- **Erasmus Mundus** — full scholarships for the best applicants.
- **DAAD** — for Master's, the best known is **EPOS** (development-related courses). It needs at least two years of work experience after your bachelor's, so it isn't for fresh graduates. Search the DAAD Scholarship Database for what's open to you.
- **Deutschlandstipendium** — a German merit scholarship paid monthly, open to international students through their university, usually once admitted.
- **University waivers** — many universities that charge tuition also offer waivers or scholarships. Look on the fee page.
- **Country schemes** — the NL Scholarship, Swedish Institute, Eiffel and Italian DSU, covered in the previous chapter.

> **TIP**
>
> Scholarship deadlines often come months before admission deadlines. Find them first and work backwards.

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08

Loughborough University, UK

CHAPTER 08 — APPLICATION DOCUMENTS

Your documents

Most programmes ask for a similar set. Each has its own exact list, so treat this as a starting point.

Your CV

A Master's CV is an academic document, not a job résumé. Its job is to show a busy committee, in one quick read, that you're ready for this programme.

What it must achieve: your projects, lab work and skills should be easy to find, with honest detail about what you actually did and which methods you used. Interviewers do ask about them. Education and grades should be clear. Keep it short, clean and easy to scan.

Common mistakes: a long list of school achievements; skills you can't explain in an interview; icons, colour bars and fancy layouts; one generic CV for every programme. Conventions such as a photo differ between countries, so follow each programme's guidance.

This is the part we work through one-to-one in mentorship — every CV tells a different story.

Motivation letter or statement of purpose

The names differ, but they ask the same thing: why you, why this programme, and why now.

What it must achieve: connect your past (a project, a course, an internship) to your future goal, and show how this exact programme gets you there. Name real things: modules, labs, thesis options. Follow the programme's length limit.

Common mistakes: a life story that starts in childhood; repeating your CV in sentences; flattering the university; vague phrases about "passion"; one letter sent everywhere. If you could swap in another

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university's name and the letter still works, it's too generic. If your grades dipped once, explain it briefly and honestly. Never invent anything.

> *"If you could swap in another university's name and the letter still works, it's too generic."*

WATCH OUT

You can draft with AI if you like, but then rewrite it in your own words. Never send AI text as it is. Committees read hundreds of letters, and AI text sounds the same in all of them.

This is the part we work through one-to-one in mentorship — every letter is different.

Recommendation letters

Most programmes ask for two, sometimes three. Choose professors who **know your work**, not the most famous name in your department. Ask at least four to six weeks before the deadline, and make it easy for them. Many programmes email referees an upload link, so warn your professors that these emails will come.

TEMPLATE Asking your professor for a reference letter

```
Subject: Request for a recommendation letter - [Your name]

Dear Prof. [Surname],

I hope you are well. I am applying for Master's programmes in [field] in [countries],
starting in [season]. I would be very grateful if you could write a letter of
recommendation for me.

I worked with you on [project or course] in [semester], where I [what you did,
specifically]. I hope you could speak to [one or two qualities you showed in that
work].

The programmes and deadlines are:
- [Programme 1, University, deadline]
- [Programme 2, University, deadline]

Most universities will email you an upload link. I will tell you when I submit each
application, so the emails do not come as a surprise.

I have attached my CV and transcript. I am happy to send anything else that would
help.
```

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```
Thank you very much for considering this.

With best regards,
[Your full name] [Batch or roll number]
```

English tests, transcripts and the rest

- **English:** most English-taught programmes ask for **IELTS Academic** or **TOEFL iBT**. Some accept a **medium-of-instruction letter** from your university instead; many don't. The visa office may have its own rules. Test early, so you can retake if needed.
- **Transcripts** for every semester. Many programmes let you apply before you graduate. Some routes need certified copies.
- **Module descriptions** (your syllabus): some German programmes ask for them to check credits.
- **GRE:** most European Master's programmes don't ask for it. Take it only if one on your list does.



University of Warwick, UK

CHAPTER 09 — YOUR PLAN

Your 12-month plan

This plan counts backwards from an autumn start. For Erasmus Mundus, Swedish deadlines or early scholarships, start about three months earlier.

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WHEN	WHAT TO DO	GERMANY EXTRAS
12 months before	Decide field and countries; start your spreadsheet	Check APS and dMAT rules; check anabin
11–9 months	Shortlist; take the English test; ask referees	Start APS as soon as you're eligible
9–6 months	Write your CV and letters; submit applications	uni-assist early; recheck fee pages
6–4 months	Interviews and offers; compare total costs	Open the blocked account
4–1 months	Accept one offer; housing; visa; insurance; flights	Book the visa appointment
Arrival	Register, bank, enrol, residence permit	See the next chapter

Print-and-tick checklist

- [ ] Write down, in two sentences, why you want this Master's
- [ ] BS-MS students: check whether you can apply straight to a PhD
- [ ] Build your programme spreadsheet
- [ ] Germany: check anabin, start APS, check whether the dMAT applies
- [ ] Germany: check each university's fee page and waivers
- [ ] Take your English test (the GRE only if asked)
- [ ] Ask your referees with plenty of notice
- [ ] Find scholarship deadlines first
- [ ] Write a separate, specific letter for each programme
- [ ] Submit early and confirm every referee upload
- [ ] Accept one offer; decline the others politely
- [ ] Apply for housing the same week
- [ ] Arrange proof of funds, health insurance and your visa

Mistakes I see again and again

1. Starting APS too late.
2. Assuming Germany is free.
3. Ignoring the credit requirement.
4. Trusting a blog's grade-conversion chart.
5. Choosing by ranking instead of fit.
6. One generic letter, or AI text sent unedited.
7. Asking referees at the last minute.
8. Paying agents for things you can do yourself.

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9. Missing scholarship deadlines.
10. Under-budgeting.
11. Giving up after the first rejections. They're normal. Improve your documents and apply again.



10

University of Vienna, Austria

CHAPTER 10 — AFTER YOUR OFFER

Visa and your first months

Visa rules change often, so this chapter tells you what kinds of things you'll need and where to check. No document, agent or handbook can guarantee a visa.

Where to start: Germany, the German Missions in India (india.diplo.de), which now take student visa applications through an online Consular Services Portal. Netherlands, your university applies for you. Sweden, migrationsverket.se. France, Études en France. Ireland, irishimmigration.ie. Italy, Universitaly pre-enrolment, then the Italian mission. Switzerland, your university's international office and the Swiss representation in India.

What the visa file usually needs

- [ ] Passport valid well beyond your planned stay
- [ ] Admission letter
- [ ] Proof of funds (blocked account, scholarship or other accepted proof)
- [ ] Health insurance that meets the country's rules
- [ ] APS certificate (Germany)
- [ ] Language certificates, degree certificates and transcripts
- [ ] Biometric photos and the visa fee

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> **WATCH OUT**
>
> In busy seasons, appointments and decisions can take a long time. Start the visa process as soon as your admission is confirmed, and read the official checklist twice.

Housing: start really early

Housing is the hardest part of arriving in many university cities. Apply for a **student residence** (in Germany, run by the Studierendenwerk) the day you accept your offer. Look at rooms in shared flats too, and book temporary housing for your first weeks if needed. **Never pay a deposit before you've seen the room**, at least on a live video call, and checked the landlord is real. Scams aimed at international students do happen.

Germany: your first steps, in order

1. **Register your address** (Anmeldung), usually within two weeks of moving in. Many later steps depend on it.
2. **Open a bank account** and set up your blocked account payouts.
3. **Health insurance.** You need proof of it to enrol.
4. **Enrol** (Immatrikulation). You get your student ID and often a transport ticket.
5. **Apply for your residence permit** at the foreigners' office (Ausländerbehörde). Book early.
6. **Tax ID.** It arrives by post after you register. You need it for any job.

> **TIP**
>
> Keep one folder, paper and digital, with every document. Offices often ask for the same paper twice.

A **HiWi** job (student assistant at a university or institute) is the best part-time job for STEM students: it pays, fits your timetable and builds contacts for a thesis or PhD. Join a language course in your first semester, and go to orientation events, even when you're tired. Friendships made in the first weeks often last the whole degree.

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